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UNIZIK FRESHER EDITION | 2026

# THA 162: Basic Theatre Administration and Management

Budgets, schedules, people and the business of putting on a show

THEATRE & FILM

## Theatre & Film Studies

Faculty of Arts
Theatre & Film Studies | 100L

OUTLINE ARCHIVE: 2018 - 2019 - 2025/2026

**Written for students, by students.**

Practical notes, worked examples, practice questions and a revision plan.

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# Why this pack exists

Productions fail on logistics more often than on talent. This pack covers organisational structures, budgeting and break-even, scheduling, front-of-house and box office, contracts and basic stage management paperwork, with templates you can adapt for a campus production.

This is a student-written study companion, not a reproduced lecture handout or a leaked examination paper. Use it to organise the topics you are taught, practise the kind of thinking your course rewards, and walk into class with better questions.

## What you will be able to do

- Describe the structure of a theatre organisation and who reports to whom.
- Prepare a simple production budget and calculate break-even attendance.
- Build a rehearsal and production schedule with dependencies.
- Explain the stage manager's paperwork and communication role.

## How to use this pack

1. Skim the whole pack once in 20 minutes so you know what is inside.
2. Work through one section at a time with your lecture note and recommended text beside you.
3. Attempt the practice questions before reading the answers. Mark what you missed.
4. Use the final checklist to plan your revision week, one tick per study session.

> **Free to download, always**
> This pack is free. There is no fee, no subscription and no payment step before download, and the full PDF is not watermarked or locked. Share the link with a coursemate instead of forwarding the file.

> **Confirm your official course outline**
> Course codes, credit units and outlines can differ by department and session. Treat this pack as supplementary support and confirm the current outline with your lecturer, course rep or departmental handbook before an assessment.

## Structure and governance

A theatre company is an organisation with money, people and obligations.

- Artistic leadership shapes the season and creative decisions.
- Administration handles finance, contracts, marketing and facilities.
- Technical and production staff deliver the physical event.
- Board or management oversight protects the organisation's sustainability.
- Roles can overlap in student productions, but responsibility must be written down.
- Know who can authorise spending before you spend.

## Budget and break-even

A budget is a plan with assumptions you can defend.

- Fixed costs: venue, equipment hire, insurance, rights.
- Variable costs: costumes, props, printing, refreshments per performance.
- Revenue: ticket sales, sponsorship, concessions, merchandise.
- Break-even attendance equals fixed costs divided by contribution per ticket.
- Keep a contingency of roughly ten percent for surprises.
- Reconcile actuals against the budget after the production.

> **Rights are not optional**
> Performing a copyrighted play without permission exposes the production to legal action. Budget for rights from the start.

## Scheduling and stage management

The stage manager is the production's communication spine.

- Work backwards from the performance date to set deadlines.
- Build a rehearsal calendar around cast availability and venue access.
- Stage manager's book: script, blocking notes, cue sheets and contact list.
- Rehearsal reports record attendance, progress and problems.
- Cue sequences for lighting, sound and scene changes must be rehearsed.
- Front-of-house plans cover ticketing, ushering, safety and accessibility.

## The producer's arithmetic

Most student productions fail on arithmetic rather than talent. The core sum is simple: fixed costs divided by the contribution per ticket gives the number of tickets that must be sold before the production covers its costs. If the hall seats fewer than that number, the plan does not work and must change before rehearsals start, not after the posters go up.

Contribution per ticket is the ticket price minus the variable cost of each attendee - printing a programme, a refreshment, a comp ticket you must absorb. Fixed costs are everything you pay whether or not anyone comes: venue, rights, equipment hire, insurance, set materials. A contingency of roughly ten per cent is not padding; it is the line that stops a small surprise from cancelling a show.

Revenue is rarely only tickets. Sponsorship, concessions, merchandise and a second performance all change the arithmetic. Model each as a separate line with its own assumption, so that when one assumption fails you can see which part of the plan is now wrong.

## Rights, contracts and the paperwork that protects you

Performing a copyrighted play without permission is an infringement, and it can end a production after the set is built. Rights are usually licensed per performance, per venue and per ticket price, and the application takes time. Budget for the fee and start the application as soon as the title is chosen.

For a student company, the minimum paperwork is short: a written agreement with the venue, a rights licence or written permission, a budget with receipts, a rehearsal schedule, a risk assessment for the build and the performance, and consent for any photography or recording. Each document answers a question that will otherwise be answered by an argument.

The stage manager is the production's communication spine. The prompt script - with blocking, cue calls, scene changes and contact numbers - is the document everyone else relies on when something goes wrong. A rehearsal report after each session records who attended, what was covered and what is now at risk.

> **Say the number out loud**
> If your break-even is 160 seats and the hall holds 150, the plan is already a loss. Discovering that in week one is management; discovering it on opening night is a scandal.

OUTLINE ARCHIVE

# Session record: THA 162

*2018 - 2019 - 2025/2026*

Year demarcation matters: a course code that existed in 2018 may have been renumbered, merged or dropped by 2019, and the department now also runs a film track. Read the year label before you rely on a code. The current entry below is a compiled map - take it to your course rep or the departmental office and confirm it before registration.

## 2018 — Archived course description — ARCHIVED

- THA 162 Basic Theatre Administration and Management
- Structure, organographies, resource management and the rules of conduct governing theatre business
- Application of theatre principles to education, management and policy

Source: unizik.edu.ng - Theatre & Film Studies course description (page dated 31 May 2018; original URL now returns 404) (retrieved 2026-10-22)

## 2019 — Archived programme listing — ARCHIVED

- THA 162 Basic Theatre Administration and Management, 3 credits, second semester
- THA 261 Theatre in Education and Community and THA 262 Administering Theatre in Educational Establishments follow
- THA 315 Theatre, Art and Culture in Public Relations and Tourism extends the administration track

*What changed: The 2019 listing formalises an administration ladder across 100, 200 and 300 level.*

Source: arts.unizik.edu.ng - Theatre Arts programme and course map (page dated 18 Oct 2019; original URL now returns 404) (retrieved 2026-10-22)

## 2025/2026 — Compiled working map — CURRENT WORKING MAP

- Basic administration remains the 100-level entry to the administration and applied theatre stress area
- Assessment typically combines a budget exercise with a written management answer
- Confirm whether rights and insurance are covered in your taught component

Source: Compiled by ZikShare from the archived 2018 and 2019 departmental pages plus the published stress areas; this is a working map, not an official handout (retrieved 2026-10-22)

*Archive means: this records what a public departmental page listed in that year. It is not a guarantee of the current curriculum, and ZikShare is not affiliated with UNIZIK.*

WORKED EXAMPLES

# Do it once, slowly

These are not model answers to copy. They show the reasoning a strong student would use, step by step, so you can repeat the process on a question you have not seen.

## 1. Break-even under pressure

Fixed costs are 180,000. Tickets sell at 1,200 and each attendee costs 200 in programme and refreshment. The hall holds 200. Does the plan work?

1. Contribution per ticket = 1,200 - 200 = 1,000.
2. Break-even attendance = 180,000 / 1,000 = 180 tickets.
3. Capacity is 200, so the show breaks even at 90 per cent occupancy.
4. That is too tight; a single weak night loses money.
5. Options: raise the ticket to 1,500 (break-even 138), find 30,000 in sponsorship (break-even 150), or cut a fixed cost.
6. Choose the option that does not depend on selling out, and write the assumption into the budget.

> **What to carry forward**
> A plan that requires a sell-out is not a plan. Build a margin before you build the set.

## 2. Writing a risk assessment that is useful

A department asks for a risk assessment before approving your production. What belongs in it?

1. List the activities: build, rigging, rehearsal, performance, strike.
2. For each, name the hazard: working at height, cables across walkways, heat from lamps, crowd movement.
3. Rate each hazard by likelihood and severity, and say who is exposed.
4. State the control: cable ramps, gloves, two-person lifting, a fire exit kept clear, a first aider on site.
5. Assign a named person and a date for each control.
6. Review after the first technical rehearsal, when real conditions are known.

> **What to carry forward**
> A risk assessment with no names and dates is a form, not a control.

EXAM TECHNIQUE

# Questions with model answers

Written in the shape your course is usually examined, with the marking logic spelled out. Attempt each one under time before you read the outline.

## Q1. A production has fixed costs of 250,000, a ticket price of 1,500 and variable costs of 300 per attendee. Calculate break-even and comment on the result for a 220-seat hall.

*15 marks*

1. Contribution = 1,500 - 300 = 1,200.
2. Break-even = 250,000 / 1,200 = 208.3, so 209 tickets.
3. Capacity is 220, so break-even needs 95 per cent occupancy.
4. Comment: the margin is one bad night wide; the plan is fragile.
5. Propose two remedies with numbers: sponsorship of 30,000 lowers break-even to 184; a 1,800 ticket lowers it to 167.
6. Conclude on the principle of margin rather than optimism.

> **Where marks are lost**
> Forgetting that variable costs reduce contribution. Dividing fixed costs by the ticket price alone gives a falsely optimistic answer.

## Q2. Why must performance rights be secured before rehearsals begin?

*10 marks*

1. Define the right: performance of a copyrighted work requires a licence.
2. Explain timing: licences are per performance and take time to process.
3. Explain the consequence of failure: cancellation, financial liability, damage to the department's reputation.
4. State the practical steps: identify the rights holder, apply early, budget the fee, keep written confirmation.

REFERENCE

# Glossary

Use these definitions in your own sentences; a copied definition rarely earns full marks.

Fixed cost. A cost that does not change with attendance, such as venue hire, rights or insurance.

Variable cost. A cost that rises with each attendee, such as programmes or refreshments.

Contribution. Ticket price minus variable cost per attendee; the amount each sale contributes to fixed costs.

Break-even. The attendance at which total contribution equals fixed costs, so the production neither gains nor loses.

Contingency. A reserve, typically around ten per cent, for unforeseen costs.

Production rights. A licence to perform a copyrighted play, usually granted per performance and venue.

Prompt script. The stage manager's master copy with blocking, cues, scene changes and contacts.

Rehearsal report. A dated record of attendance, work covered, issues and actions from a rehearsal.

Cue call. The instruction that triggers a lighting, sound or scene-change cue during performance.

Front of house. The audience-facing operation: ticketing, ushering, safety and access.

Risk assessment. A documented identification of hazards, who is exposed, and the controls with named owners.

Strike. The dismantling and clearing of a production after the final performance.

## Your four-week plan

### Week 1 - Numbers

Budget literacy.

- List every fixed and variable cost for a hypothetical show.
- Calculate break-even at two ticket prices.
- Identify the assumption that would hurt most if wrong.

### Week 2 - Rights and paper

Protection.

- Draft a rights application enquiry.
- Write a one-page venue agreement.
- Collect a template risk assessment and adapt it.

### Week 3 - Schedule

Time as a resource.

- Build a rehearsal calendar backwards from opening night.
- Mark dependencies and slack.
- Write a rehearsal report after one session.

Week 4 - Run

Front of house and strike.

- Write the front-of-house plan.
- Prepare the prompt script with cues.
- Plan strike labour and disposal.

## Where to read more

Entry-level texts you can find in the university library or a departmental reading list. Confirm editions with your lecturer.

- Any theatre management text covering budgeting and break-even analysis.
- Your university's copyright guidance for student performances.
- A stage management handbook section on the prompt script and rehearsal reports.

PRACTICE, NOT PREDICTION

## Check your understanding

These questions are written for this pack to test the ideas above. They are not past examination questions and do not predict what your lecturer will set. Answer first, then compare.

1. Fixed costs are 120,000 and each ticket yields 1,500 after variable costs. Find break-even attendance.

Answer: 120,000 divided by 1,500 equals 80 tickets.

2. What is a contingency and why keep one?

Answer: A reserve, typically around ten percent, to cover unforeseen costs without cancelling the production.

3. List four items in a stage manager's book.

Answer: Script with blocking, cue sheets, contact list and rehearsal reports.

4. Why must you budget for performance rights?

Answer: Performing copyrighted work without permission is an infringement and can lead to cancellation or legal claims.

5. What does a rehearsal report contain?

Answer: Date, attendees, work covered, scenes or cues rehearsed, issues arising and actions assigned.

## Your 7-step action plan

Tick each step only when you have done it. A tick you cannot defend is worse than an empty box.

- [ ] Draw an organisational chart for a student production.
- [ ] Build a budget with fixed, variable and contingency lines.
- [ ] Calculate break-even for a 200-seat hall.
- [ ] Create a rehearsal calendar working back from opening night.
- [ ] Write one rehearsal report template.
- [ ] List the safety and front-of-house tasks for a show.
- [ ] Interview a production manager or stage manager about one real problem.

## Keep going

One pack will not carry a semester. Pair this with your lecture notes, tutorials, and the past questions your department actually releases. If a topic still feels unclear, take a specific question to your lecturer or course rep - "I do not understand the difference between X and Y" gets a better answer than "I do not understand this course".

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YOUR WORKSPACE

# Notes, questions and things to ask

Use this page in class or during revision. Write questions you could not answer instead of copying slides.

**Three ideas I can now explain without notes:**

**A question I still cannot answer:**

**For my lecturer or course rep:**

**Next revision action and date:**

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